

Rubber Genocide in the Putumayo

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Introduction

The production of automobiles requires raw materials in massive quantities. Henry Ford tried his best to vertically integrate the entirety of the automotive production process by purchasing operations that produced all of the necessary natural resources. He was mostly successful, owning iron mines and forests in Michigan and coal mines in Appalachia.¹ Rubber, however, could not be produced within the US, and his attempt to establish a rubber plantation in Brazil was a failure. Instead, rubber was imported into the US, primarily from the Amazon until 1913 when Amazonian production was eclipsed by Malayan rubber. Although the creation of a consuming class of workers, with nuclear families and owned homes, was a crucial part of Ford's production strategy, the rubber producers that fed his factories labored and lived under very different conditions.

Throughout the first half of the twentieth century, rubber production was dominated by severe forms of exploitation: wage labor was much less common than debt bondage, indentured servitude, and outright slavery. In the Putumayo region of Peru (now Colombia) rubber companies enslaved the native inhabitants with methods so brutal that tens of thousands died in a rubber genocide. The system that prevailed in Putumayo was a brutal

1 <https://www.thehenryford.org/visit/ford-rouge-factory-tour/history-and-timeline/fords-rouge/>

one, but it should not be thought of as 'pre-capitalist' or 'non-capitalist.' Rather it was an integral part of the global system of capitalist production. The brutality of the rubber companies was a response to the demands of the global market, and the problems of commodity production determined the living and laboring conditions of the rubber workers. This chapter will examine these conditions. We will look at how a rigid racial labor hierarchy was established and maintained with the importation of Black workers from Barbados, as well as the ways in which this hierarchy was resisted. Family and gender dynamics played an essential role in the consolidation of power, and they were explicitly manipulated by the white company men to subdue both the native workers and the Barbadian overseers. The reproductive scheme they established was essential in producing the cheapest possible labor, combining force, debt, and family obligations to compel the workers.

Finally, this article will consider the way in which the system of production in the Putumayo contributed to the reproduction of capitalism itself. Obviously the production of rubber was necessary for the growing industries in the Global North, but the undermining of the native patterns of production also contributed to the extension of the market for the finished goods produced by these industries. Despite the natural fertility of the Amazon Basin, workers and management alike were fed (if at all) with canned and preserved foods imported from abroad. The substitution of imported goods for domestic production was essential in the expansion of industrial production in the Global North.

The Peruvian Amazon Company and the Putumayo Genocide

The Putumayo River is a tributary of the Amazon river which forms the current border between Colombia and Peru. The river basin is the traditional home of several indigenous peoples: the Huitoto were the most numerous, but there were other groups as well, such as the Bora and Muinane people. In the late 19th and early 20th centuries, the land north of the river was claimed by both Peru and Colombia, each of whom sent 'settlers' into the area to establish land claims and harvest its rubber. Rubber was booming, and there was certainly a fortune to be made in its exploitation, but the rubber of the Putumayo region was of an inferior quality. In addition to the well-known *Hevea Brasiliensis*, which can be tapped, the region was also home to the lower quality *Castilloa Elastica*, which was cut down in the process of harvesting its natural latex. Evidently harvesting was so severe that a contemporary observer in 1907 noted that Colombian harvesters complained there was very little of this second type left.² The poor quality of the region's rubber required production costs to be kept low in order that the product might be viable on the world market. Both Colombian and Peruvian companies operating in the region relied heavily on the local indigenous population to perform the actual work of harvesting the latex.

The working conditions were brutal, beyond imagining. Throughout the Putumayo basin, indigenous people were enslaved, compelled to labor as rubber tappers, and massacred in great numbers. In what was known at the time as the Putumayo atrocities, but which is

2 W. E. Hardenburg, *The Putumayo: The Devil's Paradise*, ed. C. R. Enock (T. Fisher Unwin, 1912), 94-5.

now called the Putumayo Genocide, tens of thousands of the indigenous inhabitants of the region were killed. One of the groups targeted, the Muinane people, were reduced from 2000 to just 20 as a result of the massacres. In 1993, their descendants in the Muinane census still numbered less than 150.³ Exact figures are disputed, but Roger Casement gives a conservative estimate of 30,000 total victims; the Putumayo region was depopulated by 90% during the rubber boom. The majority of the contemporary documentation of the genocide comes from three sources: the articles of Peruvian journalist Benjamin Saldaña Rocca, the memoir of engineer and adventurer W.E. Hardenburg who traveled to Putumayo in search of fortune in 1907 and published an account of his journey in 1912, and the report of Irishman Roger Casement who traveled to the Putumayo on behalf of the British Government in 1910, and who was first knighted for his advocacy of the victims of colonialism in Peru and the Congo, and later executed for running guns to Irish revolutionaries.

The primary perpetrators of the Putumayo Genocide were the Peruvian agents of the J. C. Arana and Hermanos Company, which was, with an investment of British capital, renamed the Peruvian Amazon Company in 1907 (hereafter PAC). Originally a hat salesman, Julio César Arana began to work with small Colombian rubber interests in the late 1890s, and in 1903 started his own rubber company along with his brothers-in-law. He soon bought out his Colombian partners and attempted to push out the remainder of the Colombian competitors. Arana and his company were ruthless - when dealing with former partners,

3 Juan Alvaro Echeverri, "The Putumayo Indians and the Rubber Boom," *Irish Journal of Anthropology* 14, no. 2 (2011): 13–18.

Arana "[took] advantage of their ignorance and stupidity to rob them scandalously," in the words of W.E. Hardenburg.⁴ When cunning was insufficient, Arana "forced José Cabrera, owner of Nueva Granada, to sell out to them at an insignificant price by threats of killing him, by shooting at him from ambush, by forcibly taking away his Indians [sic], and by the other methods for which this company is known."⁵

There is something significant in Hardenburg using the phrase "taking away *his* Indians" that we will return to, but for now it's enough to note that over time Arana's methods became more and more terrible. While Hardenburg was visiting Colombian rubber estates in the Putumayo he heard stories of Arana's men attacking his white competitors, murdering their workers, enslaving their children and raping their wives. The PAC conducted raids on independent estates to frighten them out of the region and to steal their rubber stores. In some cases they appear to have been accompanied by Peruvian soldiers, evidently there to enforce Peru's claim to the region.

Hardenburg and his traveling companions were captured in one of these raids and held for some days at one of Arana's estates. It was here that he realized the extent of Arana's criminality. Their violence was not aimed only at competitors, but was directed against the local indigenous population as well. Whereas the Colombian rubber harvesters had paid the native workers - underpaid, to be sure, and often in commodities rather than direct wages - the agents of the Peruvian Amazon Company compelled local indigenous groups to collect

4 Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 200.

5 Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 200.

rubber by force. Slavery is the obvious term for this, but what was described by Hardenburg and then corroborated by the testimonies Casement collected later went far beyond a system of forcibly extracting labor from unfree subjects. It was a regime of terror. The indigenous Huitoto were forced to collect rubber and were provided only the barest amount of food. If they failed to collect enough rubber they were punished severely, and not only the men, but the women and children all bore the scars of the lash, which came to be known as the "marca de Arana."⁶ When they grew too old or sick to work they were killed and fed to dogs. Beyond this, the company officers kept harems of girls as young as nine whom they raped and killed at will; they used children as target practice, or lit them on fire for amusement.

In 1910, after Hardenburg's initial account had been published in the British newspaper *Truth*, Roger Casement was appointed by the UK Foreign Office to travel to the Putumayo to investigate several related matters: "whether any British subjects have suffered or are in distress, and if so from what causes, and whether they stand in need of relief," as well as "the methods of rubber collection and the treatment of the employés of the Company."⁷ He was accompanied by a separate committee appointed by the Peruvian Amazon Company itself, which was tasked first with reporting "on the possibilities of commercial development of the company's properties" and secondly "to enquire into the present relations between the native employés and the agents of the company."⁸ The British subjects whose welfare formed the

6 Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 179-80.

7 Roger Casement, *Correspondence Respecting the Treatment of British Colonial Subjects and Native Indians Employed in the Collection of Rubber in the Putumayo District: July 1912*, Miscellaneous ; No. 8 (1912) (His Majesty's Stationery Office, 1912), 1.

8 Casement, *Correspondence*, 1.

primary object of Casement's investigation were men and women from Barbados, recruited in 1904-5 and "shipped for Peru at the request of Señor Abel Alarco, at that time a partner of the firm in question," some of whom stayed with the company long after their initial two year contracts had expired.⁹ Their testimonies provided the greatest part of the evidence submitted by Casement to the Foreign Office.

Casement arrived in Iquitos on August 31st of 1910, and left for the Putumayo along with the commission from the PAC on September 14th. Casement stayed in the Amazon, visiting various stations within the Putumayo, interviewing company employees and observing the operations until December. His two page preliminary report notes that the charges brought by the men from Barbados against the company "were of the most atrocious kind, and added to the accumulating weight of evidence that we had gathered from station to station, and the condition of the Indian population as we had opportunity to observe it in passing, they left no doubt in our minds that the worst charges against the company's agents were true."¹⁰ In the testimonies, however, the men from Barbados do not figure as mere witnesses to the company's white agents' atrocities against the native population. Rather they testify in part against themselves, revealing a subjectivity in which they are both the recipients and dealers of terror - active, if often reluctant, participants in the construction of a racialized labor hierarchy.

⁹ Casement, *Correspondence*, 7.

¹⁰ Casement, *Correspondence*, 3.

Although the men from Barbados were initially told that they would be contracted as laborers, there were signs that this was false even before they arrived in Peru. When they arrived in Manaus on the way up the Amazon river they were warned "by outsiders that in the countries to which they were going they would not be employed as labourers, but would be armed and used to force the Indians to work for their employers."¹¹ Several of the men protested and asked for the British vice-consul to intervene and release them from their contracts. Their protests were ignored, however, and they "had to be taken on board the river steamer waiting to convey them to the Putumayo under police supervision."¹² Their suspicions were confirmed upon arrival in Putumayo, as the first group to arrive was immediately armed with rifles and ammunition and sent into the jungle on a raid against the indigenous Andokes people. This raid was in part an attempt to secure labor for the collection of rubber, but it served another purpose as well. The Andokes had previously attacked a group of Colombian settlers who had come to enslave them, and had stolen their rifles. The Barbadians were sent out "on what were termed punitive expeditions" to kill or capture the responsible native people and to recover the lost rifles.

This was to become a pattern, in which the hired Barbadians would be placed between the indigenous people of the Putumayo and their white Colombian or Peruvian oppressors. They were given the jobs that were considered too dangerous or unpleasant for the whites. The rubber which was collected by the indigenous workers had to be carried on foot through

¹¹ Casement, *Correspondence*, 11.

¹² Casement, *Correspondence*, 11.

difficult forest paths obstructed by deep mud, rivers, and fallen trees. The journey from the furthest rubber station to the river was 70 miles, and took four or five days to traverse. Casement notes that "The Indians were not supplied with food for this journey. They were guarded by armed men both going and returning, and Barbados men frequently were employed for this work, just as they were used, in the first instance, in forcing the Indians to collect the rubber in the forest and bring it into Matanzas."¹³ This was the general pattern that the Barbadians' labor took: they were engaged both in capturing and disciplining native labor. They held the guns that separated indigenous families and forced them to work past the point of starvation. By the time Casement arrived, only 20 of more than 100 Barbadians remained in the company's employ, but "with the exception of three men at La Chorrera itself, whose duties were those of ordinary labour, all the men ... were employed in guarding or coercing, or in actively maltreating, Indians to force them to work and bring in india-rubber to the various sections."¹⁴

These men also took part in the spoils of slavery. Casement reports that "every so-called civilised employé receives from the agent of the company, on arrival, and Indian woman to be his temporary wife."¹⁵ According to Casement, "[w]ith the Barbados men it was no doubt a more or less voluntary contract on each side," but I hesitate to speak of volition in this context. Regardless of their wishes, the women were considered "the direct gift or loan" of

¹³ Casement, *Correspondence*, 11-12.

¹⁴ Casement, *Correspondence*, 12.

¹⁵ Casement, *Correspondence*, 16.

the company, and when a worker was reassigned to a different station, there was no guarantee that they would be able to bring their wife or children with them. One Barbadian, Joshua Dyall, evidently had 9 successive "wives" - a new woman was given to him every time he changed post.

The company's interest in this system is clear. Casement notes that "[m]ost of the twenty men I actually encountered in the services of the company were in debt; that is to say, owing to their purchases from the company's stores of things they needed from time to time, either for their own wants or those of their Indian wives and possibly children, they had been debited with amounts which often considerably exceeded the wages credited to them."¹⁶

Although the contract between the Barbadians and the company stipulated that in addition to salary, the workers would receive free medicine and food, in reality the men were forced to purchase these at inflated cost from the company stores. Furthermore, once the men were given wives they became responsible also for purchasing their food and medicine, with one official claiming that "their indebtedness in these accounts was 'for medicines required for the men's Indian wives.'"¹⁷ These nominal familial ties served to put the workers in the company's debt, which both disallowed the Barbados men from leaving, and cheapened their labor, as the profits from the company store far outweighed their salaries.

Food was a central question for workers in the Putumayo. When the food provided or sold by the company was insufficient, employees "were often forced to steal food from the

¹⁶ Casement, *Correspondence*, 16.

¹⁷ Casement, *Correspondence*, 19.

Indians, or to go out into the forest and the surrounding plantations and look for it and rob it."¹⁸ In some cases they had to forage their own food and survive on "a wild herb called by the Indians 'airambo'."¹⁹ On the long marches through the jungle, "[n]o food is to be obtained ... except from the few Indians who may be dwelling in the neighborhood, and these poor people now have little enough for themselves."²⁰ Casement recounts the story of one Barbadian at a station with scarce food supplies. He applied to be transferred and "was glad to be sent to a sub-station where more food was obtainable, chiefly from the Indians, and where his duties mainly consisted in flogging these same Indians."

As we can see, the men from Barbados were brought in as slave-drivers, but they were also themselves driven. In addition to outlining the debt they incurred and the conditions of starvation they faced, Casement recounts at length four cases in which the Barbadians were tortured and mistreated by the white company agents. Every station that the company owned had a set of stocks that had been built to punish the native workers who drew the ire of company agents. Although the stocks were much too small for the men from Barbados, they were often used as punishment for them too. In at least one case, a Barbadian man named Edward Crichlow was chained up in the stocks that he himself had built. In other instances, the Barbados men were lifted off the ground and suspended by their arms which had been tied behind their backs - in this posture they were beaten with tapir-hide whips or with machetes.

¹⁸ Casement, *Correspondence*, 12.

¹⁹ Casement, *Correspondence*, 20.

²⁰ Casement, *Correspondence*, 11-12.

In most cases these punishments were meted out after a minor quarrel with a white employee. It should be noted that the punishments given to the Barbadians, while extreme, were moderate versions of those given to the native population. Where the Barbadians would be held in stocks for a few hours to a few days, a native man would be held for weeks. Where the Barbadians were suspended and beaten, a native man would be hanged until dead.

Labour Discipline and Colonial Hegemony

What was the purpose of this brutality? The contemporary accounts are shot through with attempts to make sense of something so offensive to sense and reason. Casement makes the argument in his report that the enslavement of the Huitoto people and their terrorization was a response by the Peruvian Amazon Company to the condition of labor scarcity in the region. The Barbadians were brought in to offset some of the dangers and difficulties of the slaving raids, and overseeing the native workers on their long marches through the forest. Due to the expense of transporting the rubber from the Putumayo to market, Casement says that the "company resorted to the use of forced labour under a debt-peonage system, and used torture to maintain labour discipline."²¹ But as Michael Taussig claims, this, while not incorrect, can only be a partial explanation, as "terror and torture do not derive only from market pressure (which we can regard here as a trigger) but also from the process of cultural

21 Michael Taussig, "Culture of Terror--Space of Death. Roger Casement's Putumayo Report and the Explanation of Torture," *Comparative Studies in Society and History* 26, no. 3 (1984), 479.

construction of evil as well."²² Indeed, the violence employed by the PAC was not only directed at the native workers, but at their entire communities and even the salaried Barbadian employees, and in fact it undermined the workforce by starving, maiming, and ultimately slaughtering thousands of would-be rubber tappers.

So again: what was the purpose of this horror? Taussig's analysis of this question sheds light on our initial concern with the transformation of the lives of rubber workers. The brutality of the PAC's methods were crucial in the elaboration, not only of a new kind of man, but of new kinds of family and a new kind of society built on a rigid racial hierarchy. He places the terror of the Putumayo within the context of the "construction of colonial reality that occurred in the New World... where the Indian and the African became subject to an initially far smaller number of Christians."²³ Terror played a fundamental role in this construction: terror "which as well as being a physiological state is also a social fact and a cultural construction whose baroque dimensions allow it to serve as the mediator *par excellence* of colonial hegemony."²⁴

The construction of colonial hegemony goes back a long way, and the actions of the Peruvian Amazon Company, which Hardenburg ironically calls the 'civilising company', can be seen in a sense as a continuation of the Valladolid debate: an attempt by European conquering powers to, as Jason Moore says "justify and enable the profit-driven conquest,

22 Taussig, "Culture of Terror," 479.

23 Taussig, "Culture of Terror," 468.

24 Taussig, "Culture of Terror," 468.

appropriation, and exploitation of humans and the rest of nature so as to sustain the endless accumulation of capital."²⁵ This was indeed a Civilising Project by a "civilising company" in that it was an attempt to impose a civilizational order that not only extracted cheap labor from its racialized subjects, but that actively devalued both indigenous populations and their ways of life, as well as the natural world.

But the perpetrators of genocide were not the only participants in the construction of colonial hegemony, though they may have been its most grotesque face. Indeed, many of the liberal humanitarians who were instrumental in exposing and stopping the genocide were also invested in the same civilising project - their difference of opinion with the PAC lay in the means, not the ends. I would now like to make a closer reading of some of the early publications that exposed the genocide and called for intervention. For the moment we will bracket and set aside Roger Casement and focus on Hardenburg's account in *The Devil's Paradise*, as edited and introduced by C. Reginald Enock.

Enock's introduction to Hardenburg's account is an interesting document. Enock was a mining engineer who wrote several books about his travels through South America, and who, according to his obituary, "spent much of his life expounding an economic system based on Christian principles."²⁶ Indeed, his introduction is full of righteous anger and denunciations of the anti-Christian conduct done "under a republican Government in a Christianised country,

25 Jason W. Moore, "Our Capitalogenic World: Climate Crises, Class Politics, and the Civilizing Project," *Annales Universitatis Paedagogicae Cracoviensis. Studia Poetica* 11 (2023), 98.

26 *West Sussex Gazette*, 9th June 1949, accessed at http://www.enockfamilyhistory.co.uk/Charles_Reginald_Enock_-_1869-1970.htm

at the behest of the agents of a great joint-stock company with headquarters in London."²⁷ He condemns the system in which "[i]n order to obtain rubber so that the luxurious-tyred motor-cars of civilisation might multiply in the cities of Christendom, the dismal forests of the Amazon have echoed with the cries of despairing and tortured Indian aborigines."²⁸ For him there is a great irony in the poor conduct of the Christians towards a people that he says "[i]n general are docile and have good qualities; they are naturally free from immorality and disease; they have a strong affection for their women and children and a regard for the aged." In the next sentence, however, he lets slip his mask: The people of the Putumayo are "well worthy of preservation, and might have been a valuable asset to the region."²⁹

Enock's christian brotherliness only goes so far. The peoples of the Putumayo are "worthy of preservation" in so far as they are docile and free from immorality. He projects an explicit framework of racial classification in which some peoples are more valued than others. He initially rejects the prevailing racialization of the indigenous Putumayans, saying that "[t]hese people, although known as *infieles* and *salvages* - that is, 'un-faithed' and 'savage' - cannot be described as savages in the ordinary sense of the term. They have nothing in common with the bloody savages of Africa and other parts of the world." Even his praise is built on the devaluation of other races, but faint as it is he cannot hold onto it for long. A mere two pages later he attempts to describe the various peoples in Peru, saying "[t]he

²⁷ Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 12.

²⁸ Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 12.

²⁹ Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 16.

highland and coast people were those who formed the population under the Inca government, and under whose control they had reached a high degree of aboriginal civilisation; whilst the indigenes of the forests were more or less roving bands of savages, dwelling on the river banks, without other forms of government than that of the *curacas*, or petty chiefs of families or tribe." As evidence of the virtue of the people in the coastal region, Enock says they live under an intelligible structure, in which "every village contains its *iglesia* and village priest."³⁰ In perhaps the most bizarre expression of his racial calculus, Enock develops an explanation of why the Peruvian 'Christians' would commit such terrible crimes, and why the English stockholders should to some extent be excused. To quote somewhat at length:

"Apart from topographical considerations, the sinister occurrences on the Putumayo are, to some extent, the result of a sinister human element - the Spanish and Portuguese character. The remarkable trait of callousness to human suffering which the Iberian people of Portugal and Spain - themselves a mixture of Moor, Goth, Semite, Vandal, and other peoples - introduced into the Latin American race is here shown in its intensity, and is augmented by a further Spanish quality. The Spaniard often regards the Indians as *animals*. Other European people may have abused the Indians of America, but none have that peculiar Spanish attitude towards them of frankly considering them as non-human.[...]There is yet a further trait of the Latin American which to the Anglo-Saxon mind is almost inexplicable. This is the

30 Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 19.

pleasure in the torture of the Indian as a *diversion*, not merely as a vengeance or 'punishment.'"³¹

The explanation? That the Peruvians carry bad Iberian blood, blood of a lower class. Enock's analysis exists within a rigid racial hierarchy - even his criticism of ethnic cleansing reinforces colonial hierarchy. This is a criticism not *of*, but *internal to* the Civilising Project.

It is not surprising that, as an engineer, Enock would be chosen to introduce Hardenburg's narrative. Although Hardenburg is less explicit about his racial prejudices - he has them, but they don't shine through so vividly - he shares another interest with Enock. As they describe the natural space of the Putumayo basin and its inhabitants, they do so as surveyors and engineers, cataloging every natural and human element in terms of their potential to produce profit. Enock writes: "In the Peruvian Montaña, in its upper regions, Nature has been lavish of her products and opportunities. The rancher who should take up his abode there, with a small amount of capital, can rapidly acquire estates and wealth.... It is sufficient to cut down and burn the brush and scratch the soil and sow any seed, to recover return of a hundred for one." And a page later: "The whole Amazon Valley, when it shall have been opened up, will prove to be one of the most valuable parts of the earth's surface." What's odd about these quotes is that they are sandwiched between the diatribes against the "savages" of North and South America and the extended musings on the racial mixing of

31 Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 37.

Spanish and Latin American races. It's written in a scattered way, as if Enock can't decide between the relative importance of accumulation and expounding his racial theories.

Hardenburg's account is somewhat more focused on profit, as his journey was planned explicitly as an expedition to find potential areas of investment. He wanted to take advantage of the rubber boom, but kept a keen eye on any potentially profitable ventures. He similarly discusses the suitability of the region for agriculture, noting that "[a] part of the valley is low and swampy, but the rest is good, rich soil, quite suitable for agricultural purposes, and covered with a thick, short grass. Although all the encircling mountains are clad with forests, the valley is, at present, cleared and ready for cultivation."³² As he travels down the river, he takes samples of rocks that might indicate the presence of valuable minerals.

Once Hardenburg reaches the rubber producing regions, he quickly hits it off with the Colombian rubber agents. Talking to an agent named Duarte, Hardenburg learns that "all this rubber was collected by the Indians in the Company's service, who came periodically with what they had collected and exchanged it for merchandise, &c., sold to them at rather exorbitant prices." This description hardly seems like a positive assessment of the Colombian Duarte, but it is explicitly presented as the positive complement to the maltreatment of the local inhabitants of the region by the Peruvians: "... the greatest portion of [the Huitotos] were in the service of the Peruvian Amazon Company, which, Duarte informed me, treated them very harshly, obliging them to work night and day without the slightest remuneration."

³² Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 55.

Further anecdotes are meant to reflect well on the treatment of the Huitoto by the Colombian settlers, such as the observation that the native employees of the Colombian firms wear European clothes, but this purported concern for the welfare of the local inhabitants of the Putumayo is undermined by a description of the Christmas celebration that Hardenburg passes with the Colombian rubber men: "Then López brought out a small barrel of the indispensable *aguardiente*, and everybody, including the sick policemen, their Cioni boatmen, and Perkins and myself, got on more or less of a jag, which lasted all day, and was not interrupted even by the death of one of López' Indians, who, it seems, had been ailing for some time."³³

A few days after the Christmas celebration, Hardenburg entered into negotiations to purchase stock in one of the Colombian rubber companies. Unfortunately for him, the negotiations were cut short when the Peruvian Amazon Company, accompanied by Peruvian soldiers, launched a raid on the Colombian rubber settlements, massacred the workers and agents, and took Hardenburg and his traveling mate captive. It is in captivity that Hardenburg witnessed the bulk of the atrocities that would inform his report which broke the news of the Putumayo Genocide to the English speaking world. It is clear, however, that what he witnessed before he saw the atrocities, what he witnessed while meeting and dealing with the Colombian rubber agents still formed part of the erasure of indigenous life and community in the service of rubber production. The colonial hegemony imposed on the Putumayo region

33 Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 134.

was upheld not only by the atrocities committed by Arana and his agents, but by the cheating of native rubber workers, the enforcing of European customs, the undermining of indigenous production, and the callous disregard for native life expressed by Hardenburg and Enock in their accounts.

Resistance

Despite Casement's lament that "the Amazon Indian is by nature docile and obedient," and that his "weakness of character and docility of temperament are no match for the dominating ability of those with European blood in their veins,"³⁴ it would be wrong to characterize the indigenous peoples of the Amazon as mere passive recipients of civilizational violence. In his introductory remarks to the republication of Peruvian Judge Valcarcel's *El Proceso del Putumayo*, Alberto Chirif outlines a long lineage of resistance by Indigenous Amazonians to European colonization. He identifies three successive periods in which different justifications were claimed for the domination of the indigenous Americans.³⁵ Initially, the indigenous peoples were subjugated and enslaved by Europeans on the grounds that they were no human, but after the papal bull of 1537 which declared their humanity, the justification shifted. The natives peoples of the Americas were now considered human but atheists, and the west was justified in taking responsibility for their salvation. Finally, with the development of secularism in the 19th century, the theory of evolution was taken up by the advocates of

³⁴ Casement, *Correspondence*, 10-11.

³⁵ Carlos A. Valcárcel, *El Proceso Del Putumayo y Sus Secretos Inauditos* (CETA, 2004), 28.

western civilization who framed indigenous peoples as savage enemies of civilization. However, as Chirif notes, each of these successive justifications for conquest were in reality cumulative - they built on each other to further the civilizing project.³⁶ In the development of this logic, any action that the indigenous peoples took was framed negatively. If they fought back they were considered as either subhuman or heathen savages, and if they didn't then they had "weakness of character and docility of temperament." Moments of resistance especially were incorporated into the civilizing narrative as justifying the brutal methods of subjugation.

In the case of Peru, the state was interested in incorporating the resource-rich Amazon into the national economy, as it was being under-utilized by its inhabitants.³⁷ In the 1860s, Peru began to assert its presence in the rain forest, and in 1866 sent a steamship along the Putumayo to determine its navigability. In August the steamship was attacked by the region's inhabitants, and two men were killed. In response, a second team was sent out with the express purpose of demonstrating the superiority of the Peruvians. This demonstration took the form of a massacre: an unrecorded number of dead men, along with three women and fourteen children taken prisoner. The place was renamed by the Peruvians the "port of Punishment."³⁸

This pattern of indigenous resistance to Peruvian incursion being met with overwhelming violence was continued in the Putumayo. As we have seen the first task of the

36 Valcárcel, *El Proceso Del Putumayo y Sus Secretos Inauditos*, 28: "Las tres imágenes históricas elaboradas por los occidentales para justificar su dominio frente a los indígenas (no-humanos, ateos y salvajes), en realidad no son sucesivas sino acumulativas."

37 Valcárcel, *El Proceso Del Putumayo y Sus Secretos Inauditos*, 23.

38 Valcárcel, *El Proceso Del Putumayo y Sus Secretos Inauditos*, 21-22.

Barbadians after they arrived in the Putumayo was to conduct a series of retaliatory raids on the Andokes people. These raids were characterized in two ways - on the one hand they were intended to "open up what were styled trade relations" with the Andokes people, but at the same time they were explicitly "termed punitive expeditions," payback for the theft of rifles and the killing of civilized Colombians.³⁹ The resistance of the Andokes people was used as justification for slaving expeditions: the phrase "trade relations" was a euphemism for the attempt to "capture Indians and compel them to come in and work for Señor Sanchez."⁴⁰ The primary norm of civilized society, trade, was synonymous with the enslavement of the uncivilized.

Like the Andokes people, the Huitoto also attempted to steal rifles from their enslavers. Casement's report narrates the story of an unnamed 'capitán' of the Huitoto who was being held prisoner at the Matanzas station. After another native worker managed to multiple times escape capture, this capitán sent his son on an errand to bring him a rifle that he had secreted away in his house in the forest. The son was caught smuggling the rifle into the station and was hanged. The father was subsequently also hanged, but not before being beaten with machetes. One of the Barbadian workers, an Augustus Walcott, expressed some mild sympathy with the natives, remarking that "this was not the way to punish people" and that "it was a brutal act."⁴¹ Walcott was threatened with punishment for making this

³⁹ Casement, *Correspondence*, 11.

⁴⁰ Casement, *Correspondence*, 11.

⁴¹ Casement, *Correspondence*, 14.

comment, and for an evidently unrelated incident was himself later beaten with machetes and hanged - but by his hands rather than his neck, and so he survived.

This expression of sympathy between the Barbadians and the Putumayo natives was not isolated, but such expressions were overwhelmed by conflict between them. Of course the Barbadians were mostly employed in violently forcing the natives to work, and the fact that they seem to have been compelled to do so by the violence visited on their own heads does not negate the fact that they behaved brutally towards the native workers. They were therefore occasionally the targets of acts of resistance. Although rifles were not easy to come by for the native peoples, they had other methods of resisting enslavement and death. Some simply ran away and evaded capture, but they also enacted positive means of self defense, attacking and wounding the company's employees. Casement notes that the Andokes and Boras peoples were sometimes successful in killing their would-be capturers, and he says that one Barbadian man, Clifford Quintin, had been wounded in one of his feet when they met. "This wound has been caused by a splinter of wood, probably poisoned, placed in the ground by the Indians in order to obstruct the approach of their dwelling places, in the hope of thereby hindering the armed raids made upon them to compel them to work rubber."⁴² The employment of such means of defense around their homes was not merely retaliatory violence, but was quite literally a defense of their homes, and communities - their patterns of life.

⁴² Casement, *Correspondence*, 13.

But the patterns of life among the native communities were precisely the target of colonial violence - it was the 'savagery' that would be wiped out by civilization. Taussig notes that the practices and culture of the native Putumayans were interpreted very differently by the Peruvians and Casement. Casement emphasizes the irrationality of fearing the Putumayans, indicating that their communities were fractured and they were both too poorly armed and too docile to provide much resistance. But among Peruvian and Colombian settlers, the natives were seen as almost mythically dangerous. When the Colombian slavers were killed by the people they tried to enslave, Casement's informant says that the only reason they did not eat them was "that Indians 'had a repugnance to eating white men, whom they hated too much.'"⁴³ Even the lack of cannibalism in this instance was somehow twisted into evidence of savagery.

Thus resistance to colonial expansion was turned into fodder for the intensification of colonial activity. It was portrayed as uncivilized 'savagery' or 'malas acciones' and used to justify a far greater degree of brutality. This pattern, in which resistance to colonial violence is metabolized by the colonial beast and revisited on the indigenous population, is accompanied by a great mythmaking. Taussig notes two related themes around which these myths coalesce: "the horrors of the jungle, and the horrors of savagery."⁴⁴ The Amazon jungle was a place of horrors which degrades those who enter, and the people who have made it their home are, naturally horrific themselves. In the context of Peru's project of civilizing the jungle, the

43 Taussig, "Culture of Terror," 489; and Casement, *Correspondence*, 30.

44 Taussig, "Culture of Terror," 482.

native population took on a "powerfully ambiguous image, a seesawing, bifocalized, and hazy composite of the animal and the human. In their human or human-like form, the wild Indians could all the better reflect back to the colonists the vast and baroque projections of human wildness that the colonists needed to establish their reality as civilized (not to mention business-like) people."⁴⁵ In their hybrid identity, the native peoples of the Amazon served a dual purpose for the rubber companies: they were both the engines of civilization as laborers, and the object of civilization as savages in want of pacification.

For the companies and state actors engaged in the project of civilizing the jungle, the acts of resistance by the indigenous Amazonians were crucial, in that they provided justification for the project itself. The fact of their pacification and employment as laborers meanwhile - which should be considered not a natural state *à la* Casement, but a state created and enforced by unimaginable violence - provided proof of the project's success. Both the resistance of the Putumayo peoples and the violent reprisal were elements in the project of genocide-as-accumulation. They figured into its creation as well as into its reproduction and maintenance.

The intertwined projects of pacification and rubber production are not reducible to either end. Although the violence of the genocide cannot be reduced to an attempt at labor discipline, neither can the genocide be reduced to bloodlust. The interests of the rubber industry were seized on by the capricious monsters of the Arana company who preferred the

45 Taussig, "Culture of Terror," 483-4.

taste of blood to mammon. At the same time, the extermination of the Putumayo peoples was instrumentalized by the forces of capital. The next section will look at the Putumayo genocide in the context of the reproduction of capital on both a local and a global scale.

Atrocious Reproduction

As a social system, the Putumayo genocide was relatively short lived. It might seem odd to speak of the reproduction of a system that cannibalized itself in just a few short years, but the concept of social reproduction includes not only the generation, but also the daily scale. In the Putumayo, the long-term stable reproduction of the system of rubber collection in was sacrificed in order to intensify the short term collection of rubber. This is true both of the consumption of the rubber commodity and the consumption of labor. But in other ways, the Putumayo genocide contributed to the long-term reproduction of the capitalist world-economy itself. This is most clear in the way that the destruction of local food production opened up the Putumayo as a market for non-perishable goods, especially tinned meats from abroad. There are several key aspects of social reproduction to be examined here: the reproduction of labor, both short- and long-term; the extension of company control over labor, including the reproductive labor of employee's families; the reproduction of the rubber commodity; and the development of a market where sundry goods were bought and sold.

It is a primary concern of every society how it will reproduce itself. The production of the necessary means of subsistence and their distribution and consumption are central to the

structure of every social order. A defining feature of capitalism is the extent to which the production and consumption of the ordinary means of subsistence are divorced and mediated through exchange. Capitalist workers do not generally consume the direct products of their labor, but must exchange what they produce for a wage which will then allow them to purchase their daily needs - which are products of someone else's labor. Production and consumption become mediated through exchange, and therefore the worker's means of reproducing him- or her-self is likewise mediated through exchange.

The act of purchasing what one needs to survive contributes to the reproduction of capitalism in two distinct ways. First, and most obviously, it allows workers to renew their labor power. They can eat the calories they expended and rest in rented rooms, and cloth themselves from the elements so that they may be able to show up to work again at full power. If their wage is high enough, they can purchase also what is necessary to raise children, and to ensure a steady stream of labor even after their death. It is a very common situation, however, that wages are not sufficient for generational reproduction. In a scenario where labor is relatively more abundant than jobs, competition can drive wages below the point of the renewal of labor, and so the workers must either die out or be subsidized by some other entity such as the state, the family, or the church. In cases where no such subsidy exists, a steady stream of labor is often supplied by immigration or by force.

The second contribution of the act of purchase to the reproduction of capitalism is in a sense more fundamental, at least from the standpoint of capital. When the worker purchases

some commodity for consumption, this represents the endpoint of the production process: the moment of purchase is also the moment of profit for the capitalist. In this exchange the worker receives what they need to live as a worker, and the capitalist also receives what they need to live *as a capitalist*, for this is the moment that their profit is realized, their entire *raison d'être*. It is precisely this dual significance of the purchases of the worker that motivated the creation of a class of consuming workers under Fordism. But things were otherwise in Putumayo.

We have seen in previous chapters that in the factories of Michigan, only a portion of the workforce was paid well enough to consume commodities on an enlarged scale: the workforce was stratified along racial lines into well-paid white wage-workers and under-paid Black and immigrant wage-workers. The poorer workers still consumed commodities, but to a lesser extent, and their consumption was supplemented by informal and reproductive labor, such as family gardens. In Putumayo a stratification was enforced, but between under-paid Black wage-workers and native slaves.

As slaves, the native Putumayans were almost entirely left out of the wage-relation and thus excluded from purchasing commodities. Although there was sometimes a nominal system of barter whereby natives traded some rubber for sundry goods from the colonists, this served only to establish a debt against the natives. This debt could never be paid off, and was merely a veneer which covered the system of violent coercion. The economic compulsion of the wage was replaced by the direct compulsion of the whip and so labor was cheapened, but at the

cost of removing from capital's ambit a potential market. Further, the genocidal viciousness of the slave drivers undermined both the short term and long term reproduction of labor, meaning that labor renewal was largely effected by constant slaving raids.

The system of slavery on the Putumayo destroyed the generational reproduction of native labor, and pushed the daily reproduction to a minimum. Families were separated, with men forced to collect rubber and women and children being taken by company men as sex slaves. For the working men, Hardenburg states that their food was "given to them once a day, at noon; it consisted of a handful of *farinha* and a tin of sardines - when there were any - for each group of four Indians, nothing more. And this was to sustain them for twenty-four hours, sixteen of which were spent at the hardest kind of labour."⁴⁶ On the long marches through the forest, the workers were given no food at all. When the workers inevitably fell ill, they were not given medicine, but were "exposed to the burning rays of the vertical sun and the cold rains and heavy dews of early morning until death released them from their sufferings. Then their companions carried their cold corpses ... to the river."⁴⁷ The renewal of the labor force depended entirely on a steady stream of newly enslaved workers from a population that was, like the rubber trees, fast dwindling.

Although the native Putumayans were not allowed to labor to meet their own needs, they were compelled to do reproductive labor for the company. In addition to collecting rubber, both men and women were forced to work to provide food and shelter for their

⁴⁶ Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 180.

⁴⁷ Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 180.

enslavers. Casement notes that "[w]hether it was food-stuffs that were required, labour for building houses or planting cassava, sugar-cane, maize, or other produce for the needs of each station, or the collection of india-rubber, the Indians had to satisfy all the demands of the so-called commercial establishment which had planted itself in their midsts."⁴⁸ Indeed all of the houses at the rubber stations were built by the natives:

The white settlers in the forest from the first compelled the Indians to build houses for them. The plan of the house would be the work of the white man, but the labour involved and all the materials would be supplied by the neighbouring Indian tribe or tribes he had reduced to work for him. All the houses that I visited outside the chief station of La Chorrera in which the company's agents lived, and where their goods were stored, were and are so constructed by the surrounding Indians, acting under the direct supervision of the agent and his white or half-caste employés. This labour of the Indians goes unremunerated. Not only do they build the houses and the stores for the white men, but they have to keep them in repair and supply labour for this purpose whenever called upon.⁴⁹

These houses were built on huge clearings of up to 200 acres, the clearing and planting of which also fell to the natives.

The Barbadians also contributed reproductive work to the maintenance of the company. A portion of the workers from Barbados were employed at an estate near Iquitos,

⁴⁸ Casement, *Correspondence*, 9.

⁴⁹ Casement, *Correspondence*, 17.

and were there "engaged mainly in agricultural work."⁵⁰ However, only a minority of the Barbadians were so employed, and most were sent up the Putumayo to work at the rubber stations. In addition to their main jobs terrorizing the native workers, they also contributed extensively to the maintenance of the stations. Casement mentions that at one of the stations he visited, "most of the furniture in the houses had been made by various Barbados men who from time to time had served there."⁵¹ Although they were sometimes paid for their carpentry, they often were not. In one case a particularly talented carpenter from Barbados, Edward Crichlow, was imprisoned in stocks that he himself had made. This same man was at one point sent to Iquitos to be tried for petty theft, and while in prison there he was able to work as a carpenter. He apparently made significantly more than while working in Putumayo and was able to pay his legal fees with the money he made in jail.

As mentioned previously, the large majority of the salaries of the Barbadians were eaten up by debts - especially for food. Although there was some crop cultivation at the stations, it seems to have not been very extensive. Despite the long odes to the fertility of the Amazon found in the accounts of Hardenburg and Enock, much of the land around the stations was cleared and then left empty. Casement claimed that at one station with 200 cleared acres, "scarcely 1 acre is under any form of cultivation."⁵² As a result, "[f]ood which might easily be raised locally is brought literally from thousands of miles away at great

⁵⁰ Casement, *Correspondence*, 8.

⁵¹ Casement, *Correspondence*, 18.

⁵² Casement, *Correspondence*, 18.

expense, and often in insufficient quantity."⁵³ Although the terms of the contract stipulated that food would be provided to the Barbadians, in reality they often had to purchase this expensive food from the company, contributing to their great debt. Casement lists the account of Edward Crichlow, which included cassava meal, rice, biscuits, flour, condensed milk, cocoa and milk, preserved meat, sardines, salmon, lard, sugar, tea, and cod roes. All of these except the cassava, the rice, the flour and the tea were in tins. In addition to these foodstuffs were pots, pans, tobacco, soap, and other small items, along with a large quantity of cotton goods.⁵⁴

Casement seemed baffled by the substitution of imported goods for locally grown food, and it is on some level baffling. The immediate decision to undermine local agriculture and rely on tinned food was certainly not made in the name of profit or efficiency. However, there are several possible explanations. Destroying the ability of the native workers to cultivate their own food put them more thoroughly at the mercy of the company. Starvation was a major element of the terror imposed on the Putumayans, and was crucial in the destruction of native communities. Once captured, native women and children seemed to be more prized as sexual objects - both for the enjoyment of company men and as debt-anchors for the Barbadian workers - than as agricultural workers. As for the Barbadians, reliance on food purchased from the station stores was a way for the company to claw back their wages and then some.

Whatever its immediate cause, the erosion of subsistence labor served a vital role in the reproduction of capitalism as a global system. The purchase and consumption of imported

⁵³ Casement, *Correspondence*, 18.

⁵⁴ Casement, *Correspondence*, 22.

goods served the extension of the valorization of production in the Global North. Marx writes of the agricultural revolution in Europe that "[t]he expropriation and eviction of a part of the agricultural population not only set free for industrial capital the workers, their means of subsistence and the materials of their labour; it also created the home market."⁵⁵ The means of subsistence that were formerly provided outside the market by the reproductive labor of the family and community have been turned into commodities; they "are now transformed into articles of manufacture, the markets for which are found precisely in the country districts."⁵⁶ Marx is speaking of the division between the town and country side in Europe, but the dynamic holds true on the global scale: the peripheral countries which provided raw materials to the manufacturing companies of the capitalist core, themselves served as markets for the core's finished goods.

The importation of tinned foodstuffs and other commodities into the Putumayo was a moment in the global reconfiguration of the dynamics of capital's reproduction. Historian Geoff Bertram, in a study of Peruvian imports, classifies the use cases of imported goods in several categories. Consumer goods imports, such as food, clothing, medicine, and other commodities, fluctuated between 30% and 40% of imports between 1891 and 1930. The value of this category rose from about 5,000 soles in the 1890s to consistently over 50,000 in the 1920s.⁵⁷ This was by far the largest absolute growth of any import category during these years.

⁵⁵ Karl Marx, *Capital: A Critique of Political Economy*, trans. Ben Fowkes, vol. 1 (Pelican Books, 1976), 910.

⁵⁶ Marx, *Capital*, vol. 1, 911.

⁵⁷ Geoff Bertram, "End-Use Classification of Peruvian Imports, 1891-1972," St Antonys College Oxford, 1977.

Other categories, such as manufacturing inputs and fuel fell as a proportion of total imports, while agricultural inputs, such as livestock feed grew slightly. The biggest proportional growth in imports was capital goods such as agricultural equipment and machinery - from less than 5% to over 15%.

During this period, the United States grew to be by far Peru's greatest trading partner. In the 1890s, the US accounted for barely 10% of imports to Peru and most years that decade received a yet smaller proportion of its exports. By the mid 1910s, the US accounted for over 50% of Peru's trading, both imports and exports.⁵⁸ The US was displacing the United Kingdom, which fell from over a third of imports and half of exports to about 20% of each over the same period. Some of this change was the result of trade disruptions during the first world war, but the trend of declining trade with Britain and increasing trade with the US had been well established prior to the war.

Exemplary of this dynamic of Peru importing US consumer goods was the meat packing industry. Centered in Chicago, the meatpacking industry was highly rationalized - the automation of Chicago slaughterhouses had even provided inspiration for the automotive assembly line. This industry was growing rapidly during the late 19th and early 20th centuries, and in 1909 over 88 million animals were slaughtered for food, mostly hogs and cows but also sheep.⁵⁹ This massive operation fed the meatpacking business, and in 1910

58 Dirección de Estadística del Ministerio de Fomento, *Extracto Estadístico correspondiente al año 1918* (Lima, Peru, 1919), 57.

59 US Census Bureau, *Slaughtering and Meatpacking* (1910), 345.

exports were in excess of \$130 million.⁶⁰ Much of this was canned, salted, pickled or otherwise cured meat - precisely the goods sold at exorbitant prices to the Barbadian workers in the Putumayo.

Conclusion

By the time Casement had arrived in Peru, both the population of the indigenous residents of the Putumayo and the rubber output of the region had fallen considerably: from about 50,000 inhabitants in 1906 to "not more than 8,000 in 1911," and from 645,000 kilograms of rubber to 236,000 in the same period. Despite this, Casement's notes that the individuals exploiting the Putumayo seemed unconcerned: "The disappearance of the London company as an active factor restricts the necessities of profit finding to a narrower field. While it needed a heavy output of hundreds of tons of rubber in 1906 upon which to found an appeal to British investors or speculators in 1907 ... a diminished yield of only 200 tons will still maintain many families and individuals on the spot."⁶¹

According to the correspondence included in Casement's consular report, by July of 1911 the Peruvian government had issued more than 200 arrest warrants for the perpetrators of the Putumayo genocide. However, "[m]any [had] escaped to Brazil. Only accessories remain[ed] in the territory."⁶² Many of the warrants were voided by Peruvian courts or tied up

60 US Census Bureau, *Slaughtering and Meatpacking*, 329.

61 Casement, *Correspondence*, 157.

62 Casement, *Correspondence*, 147.

in bureaucratic technicalities in an attempt to bury the matter.⁶³ In 1913 the Peruvian Amazon Company was dissolved, but Arana maintained his estates and continued exploiting their rubber and residents.⁶⁴ Over 6,000 inhabitants of the Putumayo - evidently most of the remaining residents, if Casement's numbers were correct - were forced to leave their home territory in the late 1920s by two of Arana's managers. Half of them died on the march.⁶⁵ In the 1920s Arana became a Peruvian senator. In 1927 the territorial conflict over the Putumayo was finally settled between Peru and Colombia in favor of Colombia. Arana resisted the treaty, but managed to ensure that he would be compensated for his property. A Colombian bank bought Arana's rights, but he died before receiving the full payment. In the 1980s, a Colombian bank paid his heirs \$160,000.⁶⁶ Taussig approvingly cites Edmund Morel's claim that the intervention spearheaded by Casement was one of the "only two [occasions] in which British diplomacy rose above the commonplace" and helped bring an end to the genocide. I'm not so sure. The rubber genocide in the Putumayo did not end because of external pressure, but because Arana ran out of people to kill.

The genocide cannot be reduced to its economic dimension. Taussig refers to market pressure as a 'trigger' - not the sole cause of the genocide, just its immediate context. But although the market may not have demanded the specific torture of the Huitoto people, it did

63 Pilar Jordán, "A Propósito de Redes Sociales, Económicas y Políticas En La Iquitos de Inicios Del Siglo XX," *Boletín Americanista*, ISSN 0520-4100, N°. 56, 2006, Pags. 103-118, January 2006, 112.

64 J. Goodman, *The Devil and Mr. Casement: One Man's Battle for Human Rights in South America's Heart of Darkness* (Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2010), 239.

65 J.V.S. Román et al., *Perfiles Históricos de La Amazonía Peruana* (Centro de Estudios Teológicos de la Amazonía, 1994), 192-3.

66 Echeverri, "The Putumayo Indians and the Rubber Boom," 17.

demand a radical reconfiguration of life in the Putumayo. Meeting the market demand for rubber in previously unimagined quantities required a logic of extraction to be imposed on the land, and labor discipline to be imposed on the workers. New forms of social and capital reproduction developed in response to the rise of industry in the Global North - both its need for raw material inputs, and its need for an increased market for consumer goods. The structure of the global market made way for this reconfiguration to be borne out by especially bloodthirsty actors in the remote region of the Putumayo.